Mandatory writing-centre referral in first-year composition: a stepped-wedge cluster trial

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Abstract

Eighteen composition sections moved from optional to mandatory writing-centre referral in random order. The effect on final-essay scores was small and not statistically significant (d = 0.19).

1. Methods

Design: stepped-wedge cluster-randomised trial over three terms. Participants: 845 students in 18 first-year composition sections. Intervention: mandatory referral to the writing centre for each major assignment. Comparator: optional referral (usual practice). Primary outcome: final-essay score on a common rubric, marked blind to condition.

2. Results

Final-essay scores did not differ significantly (standardised mean difference d = 0.19, 95% CI -0.02 to 0.40, p = .08).

3. Limitations

Writing-centre attendance in the mandatory condition was only 68%, which dilutes the effect, and secular trends across terms are hard to separate from the intervention.

Fictional paper generated to test evidence-table extraction. Authors, journal, data and results are invented.